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A SIXER Congress leaders with the '6G' poll placards at the 'Vijayabheri Maharally', in Rangareddy, Sept. 17

BATTLE FOR TELANGANA

THE CONGRESS SHOWS ITS HAND

Rs 500 each and free travel for women on state-run buses," she declared. By getting Sonia to do it, the Congress was trying to revive an emotional bond tied to statehood—as a promise she had redeemed. For all its renewed optimism, though, the Congress is in a piquant position. The rival camps are full of former colleagues—those who had defected, after being elected on the party ticket, to the BRS and even to the BJP. What it's riding on is a perceptible turn in its favour, helped along by the electoral triumph in contiguous Karnataka earlier this year. It is also taking on the BRS on the welfare plank by promising the "6G rollout"—poll freebies covering six crucial segments like women, farmers and students.

THE CONGRESS CAN BE CERTAIN OF ONLY 40 SEATS NOW. CAN IT BUILD ON THE CURRENT MOMENTUM?

"Anti-incumbency is strong and the countdown for the corrupt BRS regime has begun," says state Congress chief A. Revanth Reddy, claiming that support for his party will swell as elections draw near. But anti-incumbency alone may not suffice. Though it has tried to present a collective leadership of late, the party is riven by squabbles among its middle-rung leaders. Harathi Vageesan, who teaches political science at NALSAR University, Hyderabad, says the ticket distribution strategy may decide how that pans out. "The Congress is upbeat because it knows it'll do better than in the last election, but is that enough for victory? We can't say for sure now," he says, adding how it articulates its message to the OBCs and the youth will be crucial.

Analysts say the Congress can be certain of only 40 seats in the 119-member assembly as of now, mostly in south Telangana, where it wields influence. This includes the Nalgonda, Khammam and Mahabubnagar regions besides the outskirts of Hyderabad. The ruling BRS holds sway elsewhere except in the capital city where the BJP and the AIMIM also enjoy wide support. Contestants with an individual draw may be crucial in a three-way split in the anti-incumbency vote. Besides the BJP, the BSP, led by IPS officer R.S. Praveen Kumar, who resigned to lead the Dalits in the state, too, will cream that sentiment—it's poised to wean away a few thousand voters in many constituencies. In a fierce contest, where every vote counts, the Congress will be looking for consolidation.

The party, though, is still in the process of developing a social engineering strategy like it did in Karnataka. The big challenge lies in getting the Backward Classes and Scheduled Caste voters onboard (they constitute 70 per cent of the electorate), especially the Madiga SC community. A slight shift in these voting blocs could benefit the Congress. "The BRS has policies like BC Bandhu and Dalitabandhu to retain their support. What can the Congress offer?" asks Kiran Kumar Gowd, president of the All India OBC Students Forum. The party will not only have to find a credible answer to that key question, it will also have to ensure the message is spread far and wide among the masses. ■